



OFF-SIDE

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INDIA'S PARIS MEDAL TALLY PAINTS A BLEAK PICTURE

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India's performance at the Paris Olympics was a bit like expecting a grand feast that ended with a lukewarm cup of tea and some stale biscuits. Experts and national sports federations had confidently predicted that the country would finally breach the double-digit medal mark for the first time in history. There was a buzz in the air, as everyone expected an early Diwali.

Yet, as the Games wrapped up, India just had six medals, one shy of the seven won in Tokyo 2021. The absence of gold and a solitary silver medal landed the country in the 71st position on the final table.

The campaign had a promising start. Manu Bhaker nabbed back-to-back bronze medals in air pistol within the first five days, and it felt like the beginning of a triumphant story. But soon, the narrative shifted to a series of letdowns, as many medal hopefuls failed to live up to their promise despite years of support from the government and various organisations.

There were other heroes, though: Sarabjot Singh and Swapnil Kusale, with their sharp shooting, and the relentless Aman Sehrawat, who became India's youngest Olympic medallist at 21. They spattered the disappointing days with smidges of joy.

The men's hockey team, despite being in the "group of death" with Belgium, Australia, and Argentina, glided into the knockouts as the second-placed team after a historic, long-awaited win over the Aussies. And even with a man down — after an early red card to Amit Rohidas in the quarterfinals — the team prevailed over Great Britain in a dramatic shootout. However, its penalty corner conversion rate — an abysmal two out of 11 — proved to be the Achilles' heel in the semifinal against Germany. PR Sreejesh, the wall from Tokyo, stood firm once more, ensuring India won consecutive Olympic bronze medals with a 2-1 win over Spain.

Neeraj Chopra, our silver lining, threw further than his Tokyo gold-winning mark but had to settle for second place as Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem set an Olympic record with a 92.97m throw.

Six fourth-place finishes might suggest that the future looks promising — a lull before the storm of success. But these results raise more questions about the athletes' mental toughness and dedication rather than indicating significant progress.

Prakash Padukone, who had slayed many Chinese and Danes on his own in the badminton court, didn't mince words in his sharp critique. "The players need to introspect and not just keep asking for more from the federations. They need to ask themselves whether they are working hard enough, because all these players have their own physios and all the facilities. I don't think any other country, including the US, has so many facilities," the former All England champion said.

The unfortunate disqualification of Vinesh Phogat for exceeding the weight limit ahead of the women's 50kg freestyle wrestling final, along with other tales of drastic weight cuts by athletes like Nikhat Zareen and Antim Panghal, also casts a shadow over the professional aptitudes of the extensive entourages that accompanied these athletes to Paris.

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There is an urgent need to broaden the horizon, a call to arms (and legs) for wider participation, and a more thoughtful spreading of funds across all age groups. India needs a nationwide initiative to find and nurture talent from an early stage.

You can't just water a few plants and expect a lush, vibrant garden.